

SHUTTERSTOCK

**WATCH OUT FOR**
The park's engaging Interpretation Centre, near the Rajamallay checkpost, where the history of the region and its fauna is exhibited on panel displays

**VISIT**
In Sept.-Oct., well before the park is closed for calving season from Jan. through March

## Eravikulam National Park, Kerala

Often found scurrying down hill slopes, the nimble Nilgiri tahr enjoys a decent population density in the grasslands of the Eravikulam National Park. While this endangered mountain goat is the primary reason many wildlife enthusiasts find themselves returning to this stretch of the southern Western Ghats, Eravikulam is also home to civets, giant squirrels, and a healthy number of avian species. Situated in Idukki, the national park is also famous for the wildflowers growing on its hillsides. The region witnesses the blooming of the endemic neelakurinji flowers once every 12 years, with the next sighting expected in 2030. Activities for day visitors include hikes to the Lakkam Waterfall and a minibus tour to a local tea estate (both conducted by the forest department).



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## Simlipal National Park, Odisha

Celebrated in the works of the Odia poet Radhanath Ray, and having inspired multiple legends thanks to its raw beauty and floral bounty, Simlipal was named after the red silk cotton (simul) tree that grows here in abundance. Today, the majority of Odisha's tigers (28 according to the NTCA) reside in the sal forests of Simlipal, along with elephants, sambar, barking deer, flying squirrels, civets and over 20 amphibian species. Regarded as one of the prime tiger habitats in the country, Simlipal is also home to pseudo-melanistic tigers (also dubbed 'black tigers') that are sighted on camera traps from time to time. Located in Mayurbhanj district, the park is crisscrossed by a dense network of rivers, and the waterfalls Joranda and Barehipani make for great excursions. Visitors have to make the necessary bookings in advance.

**WATCH OUT FOR**
The rare hill mynah, known locally as *Sara*

**VISIT**
November onwards

## Great Himalayan National Park, Himachal Pradesh

A World Heritage Site, GHNP is situated at the confluence of four different ecological zones. This hotspot of western Himalayan biodiversity, encompassing the Sainj, Parvati, Tirthan and Jiwa Nal valleys and sustaining over a thousand species of flora (many of them medicinal), over 30 mammals and more than 200 bird species, is still quite unexplored thanks to its challenging terrain. Those making the schlep are rewarded handsomely with sightings of monals, tahr, serows and the like on its many treks and trails. Homestays and PWD rest houses are available mostly all over the area, and guides must be booked for trekking (via the national park website).

**WATCH OUT FOR**
The many nature trails across the scenic mountain villages of Sainj and Tirthan, and the hour-long hike to scenic Seruvalsar lake

**VISIT**
During the October-November period to sight the snow leopard and the tahr and undertake lower-altitude treks



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